for both houses of Parliament. That is 60 per cent more than the 790 seats in the original structure, and enough to accommodate any expansion in the number of MPs up to the next century. In terms of grandeur, the new Parliament combines tradition with modernity—the imposing sandstone façade, peacock motifs on its high ceilings, handloom carpets on the floor and the intricately carved wooden décor complement the computer tablets on every seat. In his address at the inaugural ceremony, the PM said, "This is the New India that is setting new goals, forging new paths. There is a new enthusiasm, a new thinking, a new vision, and a new resolution."

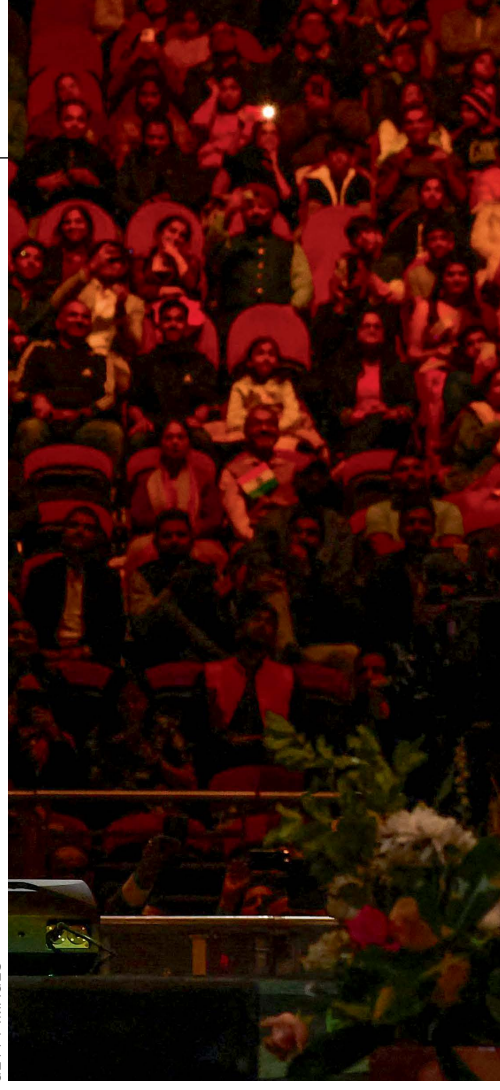
There is also a third S that the PM holds dear—Symbolism. The PM has an impeccable sense of timing in whatever he does. The inauguration of Parliament was on a day Modi completed four years of his second term as prime minister and his ninth year in office. May 28 also marked the 140th birth anniversary of Vinayak Damodar Savarkar, an ideological touchstone for the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) that Modi belongs to and its progenitor, the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh. The day before was the 59th death anniversary of Jawaharlal Nehru, India's first prime minister. His supporters saw it as a signal of the BJP bringing the curtain down on the Nehruvian era and heralding the arrival of the Hindutva epoch that Savarkar had propounded and which Modi embodies.

His eloquent inaugural speech in Parliament, though, seemed to echo Nehru's famed 'Tryst with Destiny' speech on the intervening night of August 14-15, 1947. "There come some moments in the development journey of every nation that become immortal forever," he said, "Some dates become indelible signatures of history on the forehead of time." In many ways, Modi, too, has left his imprint on history for posterity by building, among other things, a spanking new temple of modern India. Indeed, at the end of the fourth year of his second term, he has built a legacy that has broken free from the past, demonstrating in the process a style of leadership that is unique and puts him in a league of his own.

## EYE ON THE FUTURE

Examples of this are legion. When bureaucrat-turned-politician Ashwini Vaishnaw took over as the Union minister for railways in addition to two other portfolios in July last year, among the first things he did was to make a two-hour presentation to the prime minister on how to upgrade 50 railway stations across the country. Modi listened to him intently throughout, a quality others who have interacted with the prime minister vouch for too. Unlike other leaders who are satisfied with broad brush-strokes, Modi likes going into the finer detail. And so he asked Vaishnaw incisive questions, like how his proposed changes would make a difference to the life of the *saadhaaran manav* (common man). And whether it would bring a structural change to the Indian economy and not be merely cosmetic. After making an exhaustive presentation, Vaishnaw was surprised and disappointed that the prime minister did not approve it. Later that night, at 11 pm, Modi called Vaishnaw and told him why: "The designs you presented are good for today, but you must come up with a plan that thinks 50 years ahead. That is the thought process I wanted to share with you." When Vaishnaw reworked the plan, making it more futuristic, he got the approval he was seeking from the PM.

The same goes for other ministries. Modi is always looking for the long-term vision in any scheme or project his government announces. Bharat Lal, the soft-spoken director-general of the National Centre for Good Governance and someone who has worked with Modi since his days as the Gujarat chief minister, says that nothing he does is ad hoc. As prime minister, he focused on building infrastructure that may have had long gestation periods but which he put on the fast track by providing adequate financial and manpower resources and employing technology to monitor and speed up implementation. As an example, Lal cites the Jal Jeevan Mission that Modi announced on August 15, 2019, shortly after the



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**"THIS IS THE NEW INDIA THAT IS SETTING NEW GOALS. THERE IS A NEW ENTHUSIASM, A NEW THINKING, A NEW VISION, AND A NEW RESOLUTION"**

**–PM NARENDRA MODI,** inaugural speech in new Parliament building